

The Art of the Commit Message

Mastering version control communication through clear, concise, and
consistent formatting.

Why It Matters

Good commit messages serve as your project's permanent logbook.

They help reviewers understand exactly *why* a change was made, speed up the debugging and rollback processes, and create a reliable, readable history for future developers maintaining the codebase.

Core Principles of Great Commits



1. Format

Strictly limit the character length of your subject lines. Focus on structural consistency across the entire team.



2. Tone

Use the imperative mood, objective pronouns, and professional language to keep the history clinical and actionable.



3. Clarity

Provide highly specific context. Never make teammates guess what a change does by reading the raw diff.

Grammar & Capitalization

The Imperative Mood

Always write commit messages as commands. A good test is if the message completes this sentence: *"If applied, this commit will..."*

DO

Add contact form validation

DON'T

Added contact form validation

Capitalization Rules

Treat your commit message subject line like the beginning of a proper sentence. Always capitalize the very first letter.

DO

Fix navigation bar spacing

DON'T

fix navigation bar spacing

Punctuation Guidelines

- ✔ **No Trailing Periods:** Space is precious in a commit subject line. Omit periods at the end of the subject.

DO

Update dependencies
- ✘ **Avoid Punctuation Waste:** Using periods eats up your character limit unnecessarily.

DON'T

Update dependencies.
- ≡ **Use Punctuation in the Body:** If your commit requires a detailed explanation, use normal punctuation (periods, commas) in the multi-line commit body.
- ⚠ **Limit Exclamation Marks:** Only use exclamation points for critical hotfixes or breaking changes. Otherwise, keep it neutral.

The Clarity Mandate

Avoid vague messages at all costs. Generic subjects like "Fix bugs" or "Update code" provide zero historical context, forcing teammates to manually read the code diff to understand the change. Specificity saves time and provides immediate context for future debugging sessions.

DO (SPECIFIC)

Resolve login page crash on mobile iOS

DON'T (VAGUE)

Fix bugs



The Golden Rule of Length

50

Character Maximum

Keep It Concise

The subject line of your commit should ideally be 50 characters or less. This ensures it displays perfectly across GitHub UI, terminal logs, and IDEs without truncating.

UNDER 50 CHARS

Refactor payment processing logic

WAY TOO LONG

I went into the payment processing file and changed the way the logic handles credit cards because it was broken

Professional Tone & Pronouns

Objective Pronouns

Avoid subjective pronouns like "I", "me", or "my".
The code belongs to the project repository, not to you individually.

OBJECTIVE

Remove unused images

SUBJECTIVE

I removed my unused images

Clinical Descriptions

Remove emotion and conversational filler from your commits. State exactly what the code does, not how you felt doing it.

CLINICAL

Fix race condition in auth flow

EMOTIONAL

Finally fixed this stupid bug!

Quick Reference: Do vs. Don't

Rule	Do 	Don't 
Grammar Mood	Add contact form Add contact form (Imperative/Command)	Added contact form Added contact form (Past tense)
Capitalization	Fix navigation bar Fix navigation bar (Capital start)	fix navigation bar fix navigation bar (Lowercase start)
Punctuation	Update dependencies Update dependencies (No period at the end)	Update dependencies. Update dependencies. (Wastes characters)
Clarity	Resolve mobile crash Resolve mobile crash (Highly Specific)	Fix bugs Fix bugs (Too vague)
Pronouns	Remove unused images Remove unused images (Objective)	I removed my images I removed my images (Avoid "I", "me", "my")

Ready to Commit?

Questions, thoughts, or pushbacks?

Image Sources



https://images.stockcake.com/public/7/7/4/7743cbaa-860b-4ff7-be69-5f72981822ae_large/coding-after-dark-stockcake.jpg

Source: stockcake.com



https://images.stockcake.com/public/6/6/8/66894e38-9ee2-4969-ac40-738bc9fc3f24_large/magnifying-digital-details-stockcake.jpg

Source: stockcake.com